

that the answers were with me and that it had to be done with due urgency.

Thus, I started the project with four interns from SNDT Women's University, Mumbai. All were highly talented girls who shared the feeling of how important this task was.

I had learned a bit about accounting principles and transaction rules from a couple of domain experts. Mr Raul from the Homi Bhabha Centre was one of the initial accountants to help out on that aspect.

It was a desktop-based application that we were developing and one of our interns had herself worked in a similar capacity with Tally Solutions. Needless to say, she knew how accounting software worked.

We got the first version out with basic accounting features including elementary reports such as trial balance, ledger, etc.

Meanwhile, an NGO called Comet Media Foundation took up the responsibility of hosting the modest team that I had assembled. This NGO also provided a little funding to keep the team going.

Just when we felt that funding was increasingly falling short, the National Internet Exchange of India (NIXI) responded to my appeal for funding this extremely important FOSS initiative.

Considering my own career and the recognition I'd received as one of the very few visually impaired IT professionals across the world in those days, a presentation at a conference helped me get this funding.

Q Who are the people you would credit for the success of the project?

Many people have helped this project grow, both directly and indirectly.

Valsa Williams, who was the then director of Intel and Dr Jaijit Bhattacharya, director of the erstwhile Sun Microsystems, were my biggest supporters and have always guided me, especially when it came to getting grants and funds to keep the project going. And it was Dr Nagarjun from the Homi Bhabha Centre, who always acted to get the team

out of problems in several situations.

After Comet Media Foundation, I had to shift the project's development to IIT Bombay, where the Central government provided funding on the recommendation of Prof. Kannan, a professor in the chemical department at this IIT. While NIXI funding lasted till mid-2009, the project came to a standstill till the Central government funding came in April 2010 to IIT Bombay.

However, there was a fundamental difference in my vision for GNUKhata and that of the funding committee of the Central government. The National Mission for Education through ICT (NMEICT), which funded GNUKhata during its IIT days, aimed to just bring it to the level of an educational tool, while I wanted to make this software an enterprise quality, commercially competent open source solution.

So, eventually the project had to part ways from IIT and I started the Digital Freedom Foundation (www.dff.org.in), an NGO for the development and propagation of FOSS, especially in the field of commerce.

GNUKhata soon became its flagship product with massive funding from the International Centre for FOSS (a Kerala government initiative) for five years between 2012-2017.

The software is in its version 6 now and has a lot of enterprise quality features, generally available only in high-end proprietary programs. It can be hosted on the cloud and can also be used on a standalone machine.

It is currently taught in an elementary accounting course in the state of Kerala. The Maharashtra State board has also included GNUKhata in its syllabus for 11th standard and plans on doing the same for 12th standard as well.

We have more than 6500 active users with close to no marketing.

Currently Accion Labs Pvt Ltd has adopted the software and is contributing to the project in financial terms. However, the company does

not view it as a commercial opportunity, given that its area of work is not fintech.

Q Given that GNUKhata's mission is to replace costly proprietary products with an open source alternative, why do you intend to bring out an enterprise version of it, with a business model?

Yes, there was always this intention to make it enterprise quality and for that, a self-sustained revenue model is needed. But GNUKhata itself will always remain open source. Not a single bit of it will ever become proprietary. It is a common misconception that open source software cannot do profitable business. There are also a few extremists who preach that free software (often called open source) developers should 'never' think of business and do only social work.

Everyone has to earn their livelihood, and many have a great business vision for their products. It is absolutely fine to convert an open source product into a business as long as the 'free as in freedom' values are not compromised and the code always remains open.

What I have in mind is to build enterprise quality services, including those for GST, e-way bills, TDS, etc. The idea is to use GNUKhata for billing and automated accounting, and then connect it to our enterprise services, the latter being paid offerings.

This would give users a one-click application with which they can go about doing their billing/invoicing, while filing of GST, TDS and generation of reports would happen completely automatically.

We mainly wish to serve the technologically underserved, like the micro and small businesses, as well as some medium scale companies in certain sectors. These customers don't have the money to buy expensive enterprise quality ERP, and even if they do, the baggage of unnecessary extra features makes for a steep learning curve.

We expect our customers to have very little or no accounting knowledge.